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Rijkswaterstaat
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Beste lezer,

Met deze motivatiebrief wil ik graag solliciteren naar de positie van Adviseur chemische waterkwaliteit bij Rijkswaterstaat. De werkzaamheden en doelstellingen van deze functie spreken mij bijzonder aan. Hoewel ik inmiddels bijna twee jaar in Nederland (Utrecht) woon, ben ik de taal nog aan het leren en druk ik mijzelf makkelijker uit in het Engels:

1. Motivation

I partly grew up in the Salzkammergut, a lake district in the Austrian Alps. There I developed an interest in how water systems change between seasons, from snowmelt to changing rivers and lake dynamics. That interest continued throughout my studies. During my Erasmus semester in Vienna, I learned more about the Dutch approach to water management. I was particularly interested in how the Netherlands combines technical expertise with a broader approach of living with water. This influenced my decision to pursue my Master's in Water Science and Management in Utrecht. Having spent two years here, and now that I have completed my Master's thesis, I would like to continue my career in the Netherlands.

What brings me to this role at Rijkswaterstaat is the combination of water quality assessment, policy translation, and collaboration with different stakeholders. My background includes PFAS, EU water legislation like the Water Framework Directive, and drinking water treatment. I am particularly motivated by translating scientific knowledge into practical advice that supports effective water management.

2. Organisational Sensitivity

Situation: During my bachelor's thesis internship, I worked on an EU-funded drinking water treatment project in Kikinda, Serbia. As one of the few international team members, I collaborated with local utility employees with different working practices and priorities.

Task: Alongside my technical work on coagulation and flocculation parameters for a new treatment plant, I needed to ensure effective collaboration across different communication styles and a correct workflow of the commissioning of the plant itself.

Action: Initially, I approached discussions too directly, which created resistance. I adapted by listening more carefully, focusing on shared objectives, and explaining the reasoning behind proposed actions rather than only the actions themselves.

Result: The project was completed, and the treatment plant was commissioned, providing improved drinking water quality for the city of Kikinda. I had to leave before that stage, as I was writing my thesis and preparing for my masters.

Reflection: I learned that adapting communication to different organisational contexts is essential for achieving technical outcomes, particularly in international and public-sector environments. Also expecting conflict and being able to deal with it.

3. Content Knowledge

Situation: During my Master's, I contributed to a consultancy project for KWR on adaptive strategies for the Dutch drinking water system under uncertainty.

Task: My focus was to analyse the dutch drinking water system, interview experts at the water companies (Dunea, Vitens etc.) and write up strategies on how to tackle those challenges.

Action: Our team analysed vulnerabilities in the Dutch drinking water system, including source dependency, treatment flexibility, and emerging contaminant management. We combined scientific literature and expert opinions with the Water Framework Directive and Dutch drinking water legislation to assess possible future challenges.

Result: We developed recommendations on treatment improvements, source diversification, and adaptive management approaches, translating technical findings into practical options for decision-makers.

Reflection: This project strengthened my ability to combine scientific evidence, legislation, and practical considerations. All skills that are important for advising on water quality challenges at Rijkswaterstaat.

4. Analysing

Situation: During my Master's thesis on PFAS removal technologies, I analysed scientific literature alongside experimental data covering different treatment approaches and performance indicators.

Task: My focus was assessing the potential of molecularly imprinted polymers as a PFAS removal technology and evaluating their suitability for future drinking water treatment.

Action: I structured the literature by technology type and compared studies based on removal efficiency, selectivity, regeneration potential, and scalability. I used comparison tables and regularly evaluated whether information was relevant to the research question.

Result: This resulted in a structured assessment of technological readiness and key barriers, providing a clear overview rather than a collection of disconnected findings.

Reflection: I apply the same approach in advisory work. First create structure, then analyse, while continuously checking whether information contributes to the actual question.

Thank you for considering my application.

Kind regards,

Immanuel Dietrich